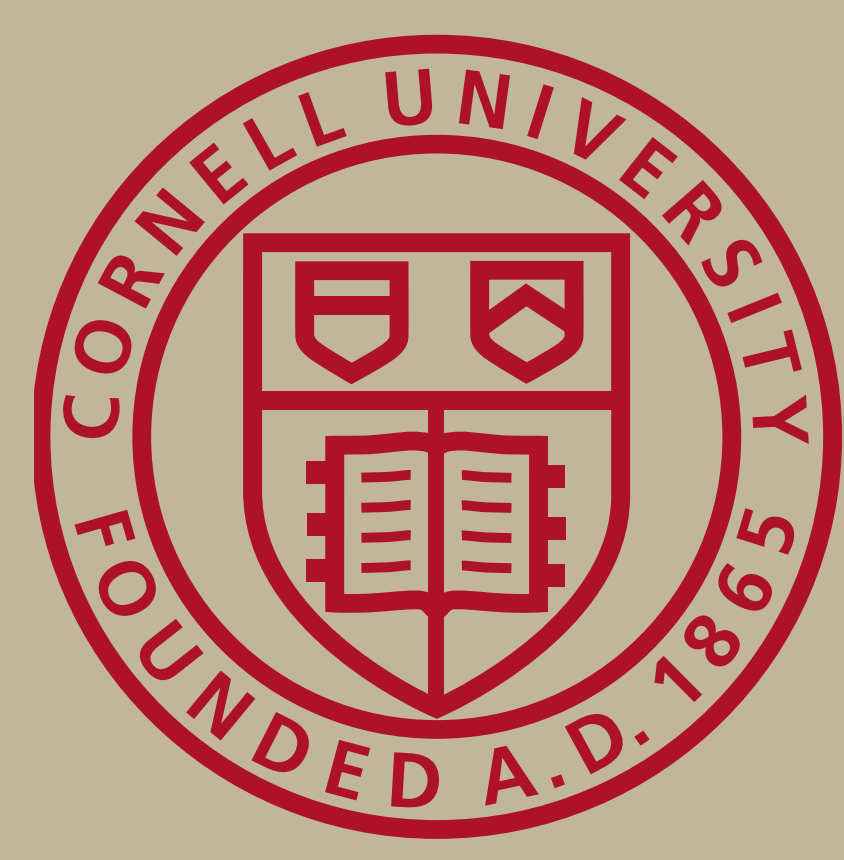
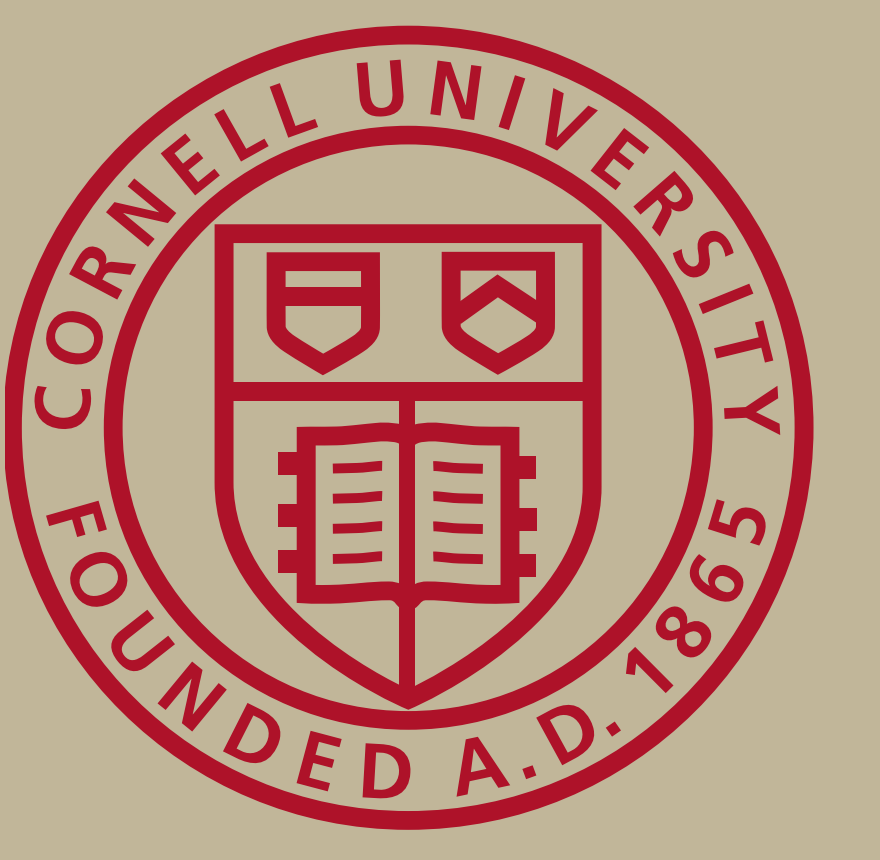




Measuring the counterfactual: Self-censorship scale creation and validation

Jabin Binnendyk & Gordon Pennycook
Cornell University



“Information is the currency
of democracies”
– Ralph Nader

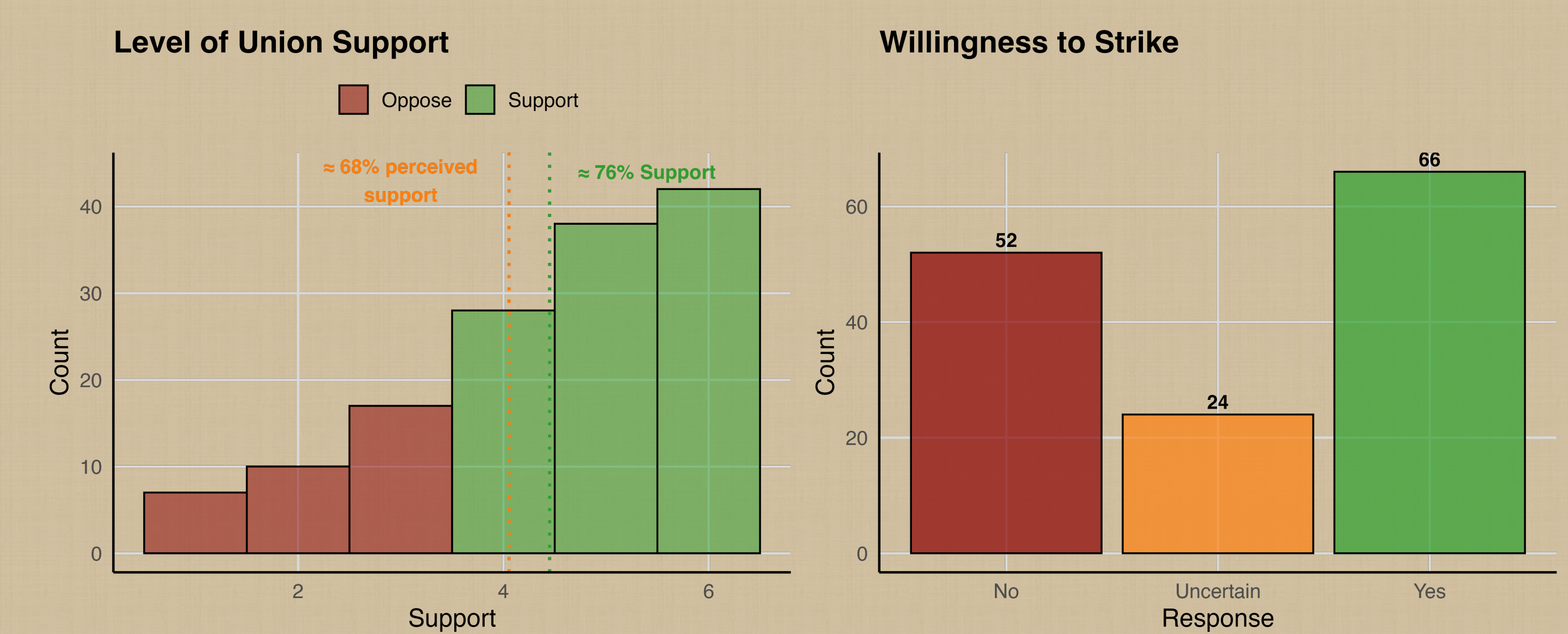
Creation process:

- Selected item pool (186 items) + nomological net
- Statistical/ theoretical pruning (5 EFAs; $N = 2,724$)
- CFA validation ($N = 1,159$) suggested excellent fit
 $CFI (.96)$, $TLI (.95)$, $RMSEA (.05)$ and $SRMR (.04)$

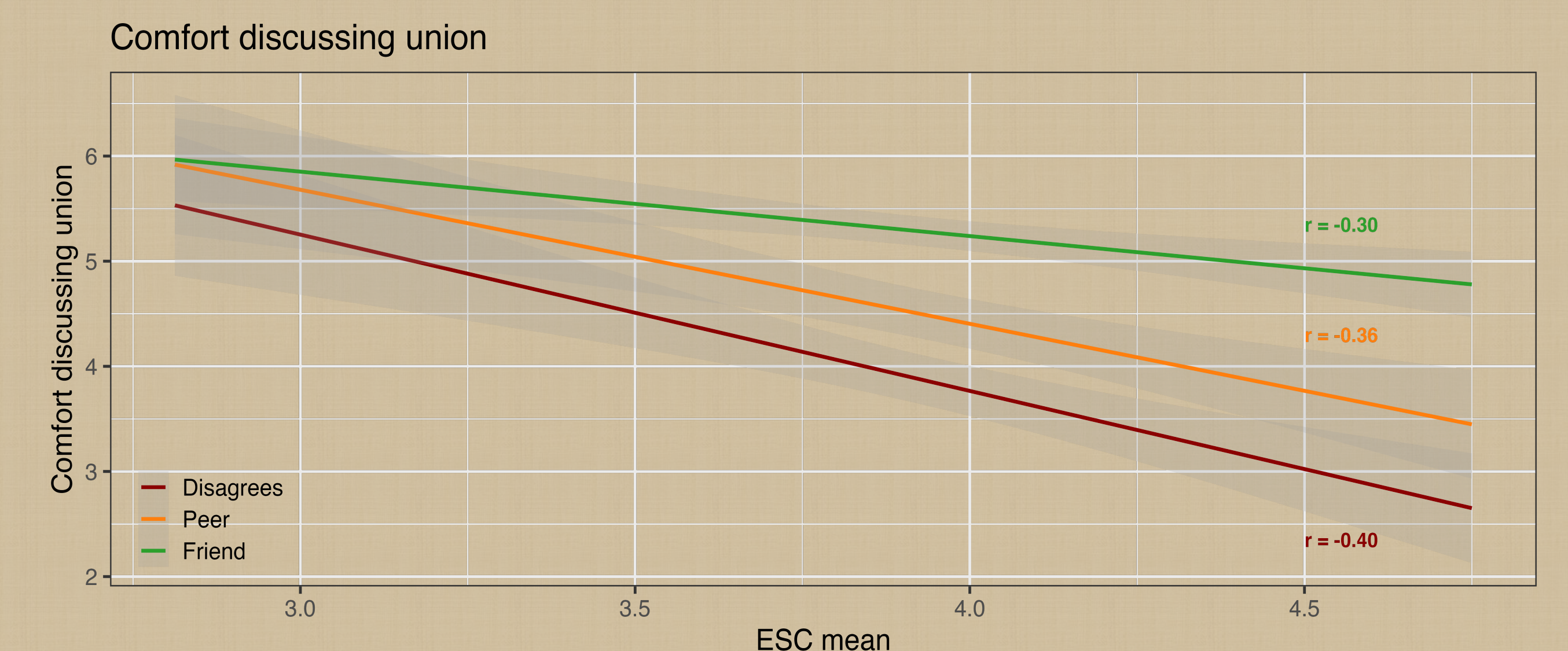
Novel application of ESC:

*Cornell Graduate Students Perceptions
about unionization*

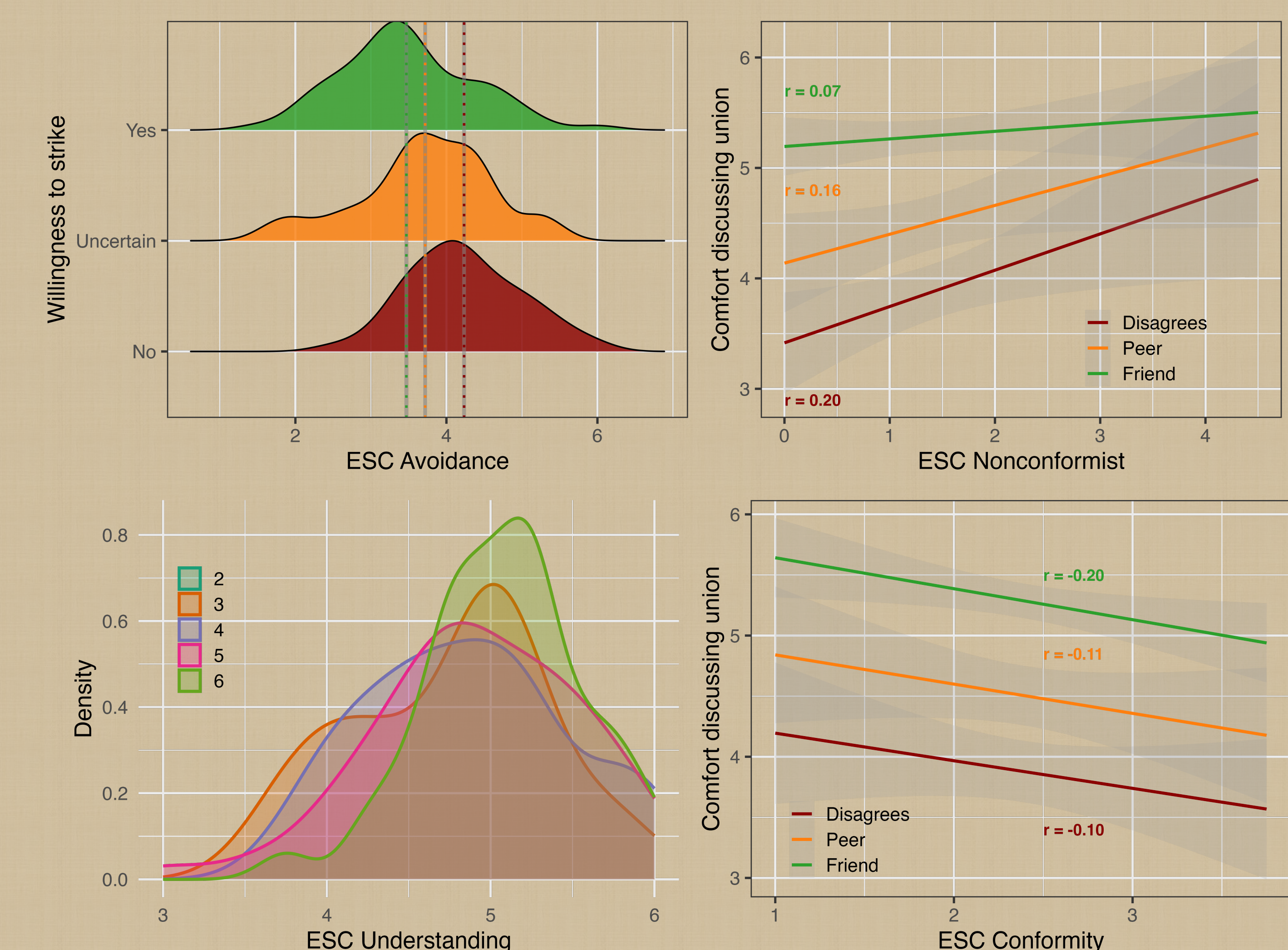
Differences found between support, n = 146
perceived support, and willingness to strike



ESC related to lower comfort in discussing the union showing sensitivity to audience



Individual subscales performance supported



Expressions of Self-Censorship (ESC) Scale; $\alpha = .78$

AVOIDANCE

ls .64 -.75
 $\alpha = .78$

- Silence is the best approach when discussing unpopular opinions
- I subconsciously restrain from sharing extreme views
- I am more careful about what I say around people that hold different opinions
- It is safer to keep quiet than publicly speak an opinion that you know most others don't share*

NONCONFORMISTS

ls .71 -.80
 $\alpha = .83$

- I secretly enjoy holding extreme positions
- Provoking reactions from others is entertaining
- I enjoy pushing boundaries with what I say
- Conversations that get emotional are more fun for me

UNDERSTANDING

ls .68 -.80
 $\alpha = .81$

- I put a lot of care into the ideas I share
- When I feel uncertain, I research the topic before speaking
- Before speaking I consider how much I know about the topic
- I take steps to educate myself before discussing something

CONFORMITY

ls .68 -.80
 $\alpha = .87$

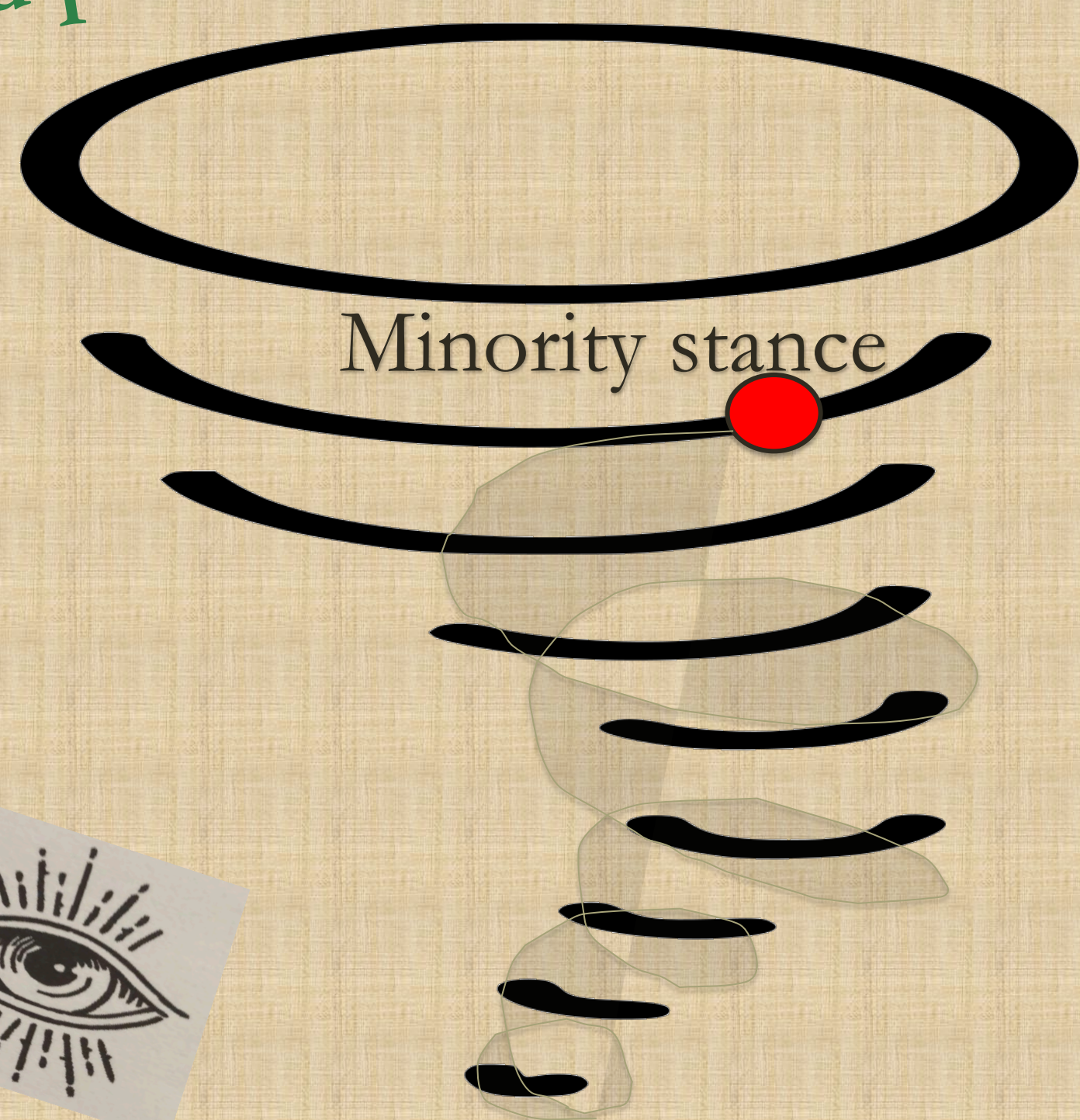
- I conform to others' opinions
- I adopt the same views as my friends
- Mainstream opinions are the correct opinions
- I change my opinions when I realize they differ from the majority

The Spiral of Silence

Crowd wisdom



Perceived public opinion



Minority stance



'Quasi-statistical sense' helps perceive opinion climate

Fear of isolation



Self-censor



Deviant
Nonconformist

BIG BROTHER
IS WATCHING YOU